

General Editor's Introduction - Dylan McCarthy Blackston

Dylan McCarthy Blackston; General Editor's Introduction: Bracketed Sites. TSQ 1 May 2025; 12 (2): 147–151. doi: <https://doi.org/10.1215/23289252-11713341>

Provides context for the term “trans[]crip”, a site for considering the intersection of transgender and disabled lived experiences. This perspective can include the idea that “trans [is] a mad site by social definition” and also that people experience “both transness and madness” (McEwan). The brackets exist to avoid reducing trans and crip experiences into one and allow for their fluidity in meaning. Blackston centers bathrooms in the piece to relate how disabling/inaccessible a trans experience can be.

The article is a helpful introduction to the journal, one for defining trans[]crip, which is the center theme of the journal, and for grounding the journal in the context of the current US administration, trans rights, and gender/crip/Mad theory. This introduction also grounds itself in the history of racially segregated bathrooms and the treatment of Black people in Western medicine. Intersectionality is merely a starting block for this edition; Blackston sets the stage for what will be an introspective, academic, and boundary-pushing collection of essays.

References of interest:

“Trans-“ issue of WSQ: Women's Studies Quarterly

Eva Hayward, Jami Weinstein; *Introduction: Transanimalities in the Age of Trans* Life*. TSQ 1 May 2015; 2 (2): 195–208. doi: <https://doi.org/10.1215/23289252-2867446>

Toward a Trans[]crip Theory - J. Logan Smilges and Slava Greenberg

J. Logan Smilges, Slava Greenberg; Toward a Trans[]crip Theory: Introduction. TSQ 1 May 2025; 12 (2): 152–161. doi: <https://doi.org/10.1215/23289252-11713354>

With trans[]crip now defined, Smilges and Greenberg are able to jump into their experiences operating spaces for trans, disabled, and Mad people. They describe the limitations of the Disability Caucus at the Second International Trans Studies Conference. They note that the classroom at Northwestern University was “laughably inaccessible”, and they make note of how many people could not be in that room. With this introduction, they define the limits of trans[]crip theory and how medical and legal discourse affix transness to disability. The authors affirm that trans[]crip discourse looks at how cissexism and ableism intersect in ways that broaden trans and disabled epistemology while also causing trans and disabled identities to be pitted against each other by medical providers and legislators. For example, some lawmakers argue that disabled children are more susceptible to transness and that trans kids are a sign of an increase in mental illness. There is also the case that to be eligible for most transgender surgeries, patients must be diagnosed with gender dysphoria, a disability, which also centers the idea that to be trans, one must experience pain or discomfort. Israel's war on Palestine is also brought into the conversation as Israel recently disclosed that it's “first trans female combat

soldier [was] deployed to Gaza” (nightmare nightmare). Palestine was also brought in to highlight transcrip theory as anti-colonial and focused on “webs of care”.

This introduction, while heavily focused on where trans and disability studies meet, is thought-provoking for the potential analysis of multiple fields that discuss gender. Medical jargon is clearly an important location, as it is both limiting and validating for trans people and weaponized by liberal and conservative viewpoints. There is also a potential for comparing language on gender to language on eugenics, pink washing, race, segregation, detransitioning, and intersexism.

References of interest:

Clare, Eli. 2017. *Brilliant Imperfections: Grappling with Cure*. Durham, NC: Duke University Press.

Smilges, J. Logan. Forthcoming. “Toward a Crip Metaphysics.” GLQ.

Kate Lynn Blatt’s federal discrimination suit

<https://money.com/transgender-job-discrimination-lawsuit/>

<https://www.tsqnow.online/blog>

Access Fiction: Clarity, Violence, and the Promise of transMad Opacity - [sarah] Cavar

[sarah] Cavar; Access Fictions: Clarity, Violence, and the Promise of transMad Opacity. TSQ 1 May 2025; 12 (2): 162–177. doi: <https://doi.org/10.1215/23289252-11710358>

This essay pivots from the idea that disabled people need to be transparent to receive proper care and understanding. Opacity, in this transMad essay, refers to the anticolonial, aesthetic, political movement of Mad/disabled people making themselves unavailable and inaccessible to abled institutions and persons, which goes against Liberal methods of empathy and understanding. The author posits the right to opacity as a means of survival, turning to social media spaces, specifically, Tumblr, as emblematic of this practice. Tumblr was/is a space for xenoidentities and xenogenders: gender identities which are difficult to explain or understand. Trans/Mad people in academic spaces also practice vagueness when they write in ways that are considered “word salad” by others - a charged reaction to the unfamiliar or different. These purposely opaque identities and practices act as a protective measure in the same way, Cavar asserts, Black transness is a means of opacity from colonial and institutional violence, which itself can be traced back to the degendering and dehumanization of enslaved people. This vagueness offers an opportunity for trans people to undermine, disorient, and complicate demands to be consumable.

What Cavar illuminates goes directly against what both liberals and conservatives demand of trans/disabled/Mad people: to clearly and digestibly describe every aspect of their identity and struggle. The neoliberal mindset would ask disabled people to voice each of their

various needs (which is a whole discussion in itself, as needs are individual, fluid, and posit the problem as one of inaccessibility rather than systemic) and traumas, so there can be what is often an imitation of advocacy. Meanwhile, conservatives demand an answer and then twist it in ways to fit their transphobic and ableist narratives (litter boxes in schools). Cavar furthers the essay by tying in the article "Gendervague: At the Intersection of Autistic and Trans Experience" by Ly Xīnzhèn Zhǎngsūn Brown, which illuminates those who cannot disassociate their gender identity from their neurodivergence and brings into question how transness is both affirmed by disability but also the movement to separate the two, which considers disability a slight to transgender identity. Ultimately, this essay advocates for self-advocacy and argues that trans/Mad people can regain control of their narrative by living in intentionally non-normative ways.

References of interest:

Zhǎngsūn, Brown, Xīnzhèn, Ly. 2016. "Gendervague: At the Intersection of Autistic and Trans Experiences." National LGBTQ Taskforce blog, June 22. Reposted by Association for Autism and Neurodiversity. Internet Archive Wayback Machine.
<https://web.archive.org/web/20210914022009/https://www.aane.org/gendervague-intersection-autistic-trans-experiences/>.

Smilges, J. Logan. 2023. *Crip Negativity*. Minneapolis: University of Minnesota Press.
Cavar 2021

Ienni, Rhea. 2023. "Access without the Demand for Explanation: Glissant, Disability, and the Right to Access Opacity." *Journal of Philosophy of Disability*, September 13.
https://www.pdcnet.org/jpd/content/jpd_2023_0999_9_12_20.

Stanley, Eric A. 2021. *Atmospheres of Violence: Structuring Antagonism and the Trans/Queer Ungovernable*. Durham, NC: Duke University Press.

cárdenas, micha. 2012. *The Transreal: Political Aesthetics of Crossing Realities*, edited by Blas, Zach and Schirmacher, Wolfgang. New York: Atropos.

Heartscape, Porpentine Charity. 2015. "Hot Allostatic Load." *New Inquiry*, May 11.
<https://thenewinquiry.com/hot-allostatic-load/>.

Page, Morgan M. 2015. "Crazy Trans Woman Syndrome." *Ravishly*, March 30.
<https://www.ravishly.com/2015/03/30/crazy-trans-woman-syndrome>.

Billard, Thomas J., Everhart, Avery R., and Zhang, Erique. 2022. "Whither Trans Studies? On Fields, Post-disciplines, and the Need for an Applied Transgender Studies." *Bulletin of Applied Transgender Studies* 1, nos. 1–2: 1–18.

Mad Trans Difficulty: The Fifth Wound and Transfeminine Impasses - Drew McEwan

Drew McEwan; Mad Trans Difficulty: *The Fifth Wound* and Transfeminine Impasses. *TSQ* 1 May 2025; 12 (2): 178–189. doi: <https://doi.org/10.1215/23289252-11713367>

This essay describes “mad trans feminine difficulty” by centering the book “The Fifth Wound” by Aurora Maria. Similar to opacity in the previous essay, difficulty is a position of resistance and a disruption of social norms. The author posits that existing at the juxtaposition of trans, mad, and feminine is a place of difficulty, specifically when existing in a saneist and transmisogynistic world. Transmisogyny specifically makes trans women unique in their relation to madness, as being trans is seen as mad and the desire to be a woman, who have a history of shaky diagnoses such as hysteria, even more so. This difficulty leads to annexation from care and demedicalization by discriminatory practices, often causing trans people to be their own caregivers. While McEwan describes how trans and madness can be a singular experience, she also emphasizes that there are still those who experience both separately, as their mad identity can be highly distressing. “The Fifth Wound” offers a narrator who aligns with transMadness, a trans woman who is both mythical yet experiences transmisogyny and self-harm, she and the book are “baroque” or intentionally “too much”: verbose and excessively feminine. Difficulty is a term both to reclaim and describe a unique transMad experience.

McEwan mentions several other works that touch on the trans mad feminine experience, which could be interesting for analysis in terms of how transfemme people describe themselves. This particular essay highlights the importance of language used by trans people about themselves, so while we are looking at media’s descriptions of gender, it may be worthwhile to compare to how individuals describe their gender, such as cis women v.s. trans women. This essay is more focused on analysing a book than the other essays, but makes salient points because of the nature of the book.

References of interest:

Gill-Peterson, Jules. 2024. *A Short History of Trans Misogyny*. London: Verso.

Malatino, Hil. 2022. *Side Affects: On Being Trans and Feeling Bad*. Minneapolis: University of Minnesota Press.

Raha, Nat, and van der Drift, Mijke. 2024. *Trans Femme Futures: Abolitionist Ethics for Transfeminist Worlds*. London: Pluto.

Peterson, Trace. 2008. “My Kari Edwards.” *ON: Contemporary Practice*, 87–89.

Neurotrans Affect: Choreography, Cocreation, and Coalitional Resistance - Abs S. Ashley

Abs S. Ashley; *Neurotrans Affect: Choreography, Cocreation, and Coalitional Resistance*. TSQ 1 May 2025; 12 (2): 190–207. doi: <https://doi.org/10.1215/23289252-11710350>

Instead of relying on Brown's term "gendervague", which can consider how autism is inextricably related to gender but not the cause, Ashley centers a "neuroqueer" perspective, which recognizes "interwoven neuronormative and cisheteronormative societal realities" (190) and how trans, neurodivergent, mad and everyone at the nexus of these identities can resist and mobilize against these realities. Ashley looks to similar anti-trans, ableist, and medical jargon used by the US and UK, specifically a case study of a UK father who aimed to legally limit his autistic daughter from gender-affirming surgery by saying her psychological distress caused her to seek "radical treatment...driven by an aggressive ideology" (Dixon 2023). Trans is considered a comorbid "disorder" to neurodivergency, both a source of danger and concern. Ashley also analyzes how this treatment can lead to trans people being "driven Mad" (Frazier-Carroll), that if they were not neurodivergent before, their mistreatment and marginalization will lead to further identities that incite even further pain and mistreatment.

Ashley's essay includes analyses of neurotrans stories (notably Chouette), Nazi propaganda, Han's Asperger's influence on autism, and post-war state surveillance on body minds and social hygiene (fears of difference that impose a threat to productivity and capital). Ashley highlights that societal fears, medical jargon, and the intricacies of language surrounding both trans and neurodivergencies lead to both the credibility and discrediting of neurotrans/transmad people. This causes tensions within the trans academic crowd for fears of over abstraction and sublimation into broader queer theoretical projects. Ultimately, Ashley concludes that sharing neurotrans, neuroqueer, mad stories and storytelling practices could emphasize the inclusion of trans in disability justice, address incoherence, and recognize a shared vision.

References of interest:

Oshetsky, Claire. 2021. *Chouette*. London: Virago.

Awkward-Rich, Cameron. 2022. *The Terrible We: Thinking with Trans Maladjustment*. Durham, NC: Duke University Press.

Pearce, Ruth. "What's Wrong with the Cass Review? A Round-up of Commentary and Evidence."
<https://ruthpearce.net/2024/04/16/whats-wrong-with-the-cass-review-a-round-up-of-commentary-and-evidence/>.

Dixon, Hayley. 2023. "'Heartbroken' Father Sues NHS to Stop Autistic Son's Sex Change." *Telegraph*, June 4.

<https://www.telegraph.co.uk/news/2023/06/04/nhs-gender-clinic-judicial-review-autistic-son-sex-change/>.

Butler, Judith. 2024. *Who's Afraid of Gender?* London: Allen Lane.

Smilges, J. Logan. 2022. "Neurotrans: Thorazine, HIV, and Marsha P." *TSQ* 9, no. 4: 634–52. <https://doi.org/10.1215/23289252-10133831>.

Escape Velocities: On the Liberatory Potential of Trans/Crip Chronicity - Ada Hubrig

Ada Hubrig; *Escape Velocities: On the Liberatory Potential of Trans/Crip Chronicity*. *TSQ* 1 May 2025; 12 (2): 208–217. doi: <https://doi.org/10.1215/23289252-11710341>

Hubrig posits chronicity, a term referring to tensions experienced in various moments and spaces while living with a chronic disability (in this case, including the lived experiences of trans people), as a liberatory method of living in a way that is disjointed from normative temporal experiences. Borrowing the term "escape velocity" from physics and reflecting on Owen's character in the movie "I Saw the TV Glow", Hubrig imagines chronicity as a way of embodying ways of living outside of the norm and refusing to follow normative trajectories. For trans identities, this can be going against the colonialist notion that gender is fixed or that a person's circumstances are unchanging, essentially pushing against the idea that the trans/crip experience is predictable or permanent. Bodies are in flux, not ideal.

Like chronic disability, transness must often be seen or proved in some way to medical providers, legislators, and the public to be accepted. Hubert also refers to the pain scale and how meeting certain requirements or diagnoses can require a level of performance (in terms of pain, gender, etc.). Much of the experiences trans/crip people have is internal and invisible to others, so even the act of describing or showing these experiences (often in a way that follows a tragic narrative) leads to misinterpretation, hence chronicity being a theory of preserving oneself by simply not following such protocol.

References of interest:

Adair, Cassius. 2022. "Is Transsexualism Chronic?" *Feminist Studies* 48, no. 2: 475–501.

Amin, Kadji. 2014. "Temporality." *TSQ* 1, nos. 1–2: 219–22.

Disability and the Sexual Politics of Fascism: From Intersex Exceptions to Trans Exclusions - Sarah L. Orsak

Sarah L. Orsak; Disability and the Sexual Politics of Fascism: From Intersex Exceptions to Trans Exclusions. TSQ 1 May 2025; 12 (2): 218–232. doi: <https://doi.org/10.1215/23289252-11710333>

Orsak argues that disability's plurality covers trans and intersex people. For example, extending legal strategies from the Americans with Disabilities Act to trans people and "intersex exceptionalism" criminalizing trans healthcare. Intersex people are assigned surgeries to "correct" their sex, which mirrors racialized conceptions of a normalizable body, while institutions criminalize trans healthcare on the basis that being transgender is not a disability. This later action exempts intersex people from trans healthcare with the conflation of intersex and disability that normalizes intersex medical treatment, such as in Florida's S.S. 254. Actions and bills like these are part of the fascist/ethnonationalist effort to "rehabilitate the nation", securing order and white privilege by curing what is non-normative or ambiguously gendered. This comes to a head with the debate on trans women in sports, a place where assigned sex assigns fairness. From a fascist perspective, one where womanhood is a mark of vulnerability, trans women (or those accused of being trans, such as Algerian boxer Khelif) pose a threat and make cis, white women the victims.

Scientific racism underscores much of modern trans/intersex/disability discourse, limiting or forcing medical care and requiring those who are perceived as other (non-normative) to reveal intimate facets of their identity and be subjected to scrutiny at the cost of safety and care. In combination with several of the earlier essays, fascist/nationalist/conservative demands of transparency from trans people are initiating a response of opaqueness and vagueness from trans people themselves. This could be a further explanation for differences in language and why there is a focus on fluidity and realness in liberal and trans spaces. The article also locates medical jargon, debate, and policy as sites of analysis for language on gender.

Refs:

Gill-Peterson, Jules. 2018. *Histories of the Transgender Child*. Minneapolis: University of Minnesota Press.

Kim, Eunjung. 2017. *Curative Violence: Rehabilitating Disability, Gender, and Sexuality in Modern Korea*. Durham, NC: Duke University Press.

Bassi, Serena, and LaFleur, Greta. 2022a. "Introduction: TERFs, Gender-Critical Movements, and Postfascist Feminisms." TSQ 9, no. 3: 311–33. <https://doi.org/10.1215/23289252-9836008>.

Bassi, Serena, and LaFleur, Greta. 2022b. "Introduction: Trans-Exclusionary Politics by Other Means." TSQ 9, no. 3: 460–62. <https://doi.org/10.1215/23289252-9836106>.

Libby, C. 2022. "Sympathy, Fear, Hate: Trans-Exclusionary Radical Feminism and Evangelical Christianity." *TSQ* 9, no. 3: 425–42. <https://doi.org/10.1215/23289252-9836078>.

Valade, Jodie. 2023. "From Injury to Activist: Why This NC Athlete Doesn't Want to Compete against Trans Women." *Charlotte Observer*, August 3. <https://www.charlotteobserver.com/news/politics-government/article277288553.html>.

Paterson, Alex. 2019. "Fox Reporter Carley Shimkus Incorrectly Identifies Olympic Athlete Caster Semenya as Transgender." *Media Matters for America* (blog), May 1. <https://www.mediamatters.org/fox-news/fox-reporter-carley-shimkus-incorrectly-identifies-olympic-athlete-caster-semenya>.

Extractive Abandonment: Trans-Crip Materialism in Transgender Health Care - Lieks Hettinga

Lieks Hettinga; *Extractive Abandonment: Trans-Crip Materialism in Transgender Health Care*. *TSQ* 1 May 2025; 12 (2): 233–247. doi: <https://doi.org/10.1215/23289252-11768539>

Against the normative assumption of medical providers to know what is best for trans and disabled people, Hettinga aligns with the notion that trans/disabled people as a community know their needs and the causes for their distress the best. Hettinga argues that although there are movements to depathologize trans people to replace diagnostic structures of care with informed consent models, the decoupling of trans and disability reinstates the notion that disability is something to be rehabilitated from. Instead, transness can be mediated through disability justice by framing transness as inextricably linked with disabled experiences to reclaim or secure bodily autonomy against normalization and value extraction. Instead of trans/disabled people living in the "wrong body", trans-crip theory pushes instead that we live in a "wrong society", that misalignment is constitutive of trans and disabled lived experiences but not a necessary condition.

Hettinga borrows the feminist disability theory term "misfit" to describe trans and disabled people. The word misfit, and the associated idea of trans and disabled people being misaligned from most social, political, and medical spaces reframes ideas of fluidity, nonconformity, anti-establishment, and anti-colonial natures. Trans and disabled distress may not be, as popular discourse suggests, between the mind and body, but between the bodymind and the world that it inhabits. Hettinga focuses specifically on the Netherlands, where "liberalism and fascism meet," and a government study titled "My Gender, Whose Care" (Das et al. 2023) frames demand as the cause for the crisis in transgender healthcare due to "an increase in trans people". Healthcare is strung about by capital, so trans people are then considered a source of revenue and, arguably, if society's perception of trans people were to change, there would be a change in demand for transgender healthcare.

Refs:

- Adler-Bolton, Beatrice, and Vierkant, Artie. 2022. *Health Communism*. London: Verso.
- Clare, Eli. 2013. "Body Pride, Body Shame: Lessons from the Disability Rights Movement." In *Transgender Studies Reader 2*, edited by Aizura, Aren Z. and Stryker, Susan, 261–65. New York: Taylor and Francis.
- Baril, Alexandre. 2015. "Transness as Debility: Rethinking Intersections between Trans and Disabled Embodiments." *Feminist Review* 111, no. 1: 59–74.
- Garland-Thomson, Rosemarie. 2011. "Misfits: A Feminist Materialist Disability Concept." *Hypatia* 26, no. 3: 591–609.
- Das, E., Wasserbauer, M., Loopuijt, C., Plug, I., Uilhoorn, A., van der Vleuten, A., and Verhaak, C.. 2023. "Mijn gender, wiens zorg? Onderzoek naar de toename in en veranderingen van de vraag naar transgenderzorg." ("My Gender, Whose Care? Research into the Increase and Changes in Demand for Transgender Care.") Research report. Nijmegen, the Netherlands: Radboud Universiteit.
- Zembla. 2021. "Grote ggz-aanbieder transgenderzorg onder vuur: Waar ging het mis bij Stepwork?" ("Major Mental Health Provider of Transgender Care under Attack: What Went Wrong at Stepwork?"). September 6.
<https://www.bnnvara.nl/zembla/artikelen/grote-ggz-aanbieder-transgenderzorg-onder-vuur-waar-ging-het-mis-bij-stepwork>.
- <https://actionnetwork.org/groups/trans-united>

Genital Killjoys and Crip Embodiment - Kianna M. Middleton

Kianna M. Middleton; Genital Killjoys and Crip Embodiment. TSQ 1 May 2025; 12 (2): 248–258. doi: <https://doi.org/10.1215/23289252-11710366>

Middleton discusses the discourse of American happiness as it relates to intersex bodies post WWII. Prescriptions of "corrective" surgery for intersex patients affirm a steady, structured, established set of gender roles and appearances. When some fall outside of the gender they are expected to emulate, there is discomfort and unhappiness on both sides. Middleton borrows feminist Sarah Ahmed's term "feminist killjoys" and creates "genital killjoys", a term describing the postwar narrative that intersex bodies are unhappy. In the 1800s, "ugly laws" "criminalized disabled, mad, and non-white people by asserting that visual differences were a basis for public condemnation" (250). It follows that discovery of an intersex patient, who does not fit into society's expectation of male or female, would be viewed through condemning eyes and therefore requiring, if not begging, for correction so everyone could be happy. As with Jim Crow, ugly laws and intersex surgeries are meant to pacify the white, abled, normative public. The potential for an erotic future also justifies these corrective treatments, as gender is viewed

through what is desirable and sexual. The civil rights movements blurred racial boundaries and "troubl[ed] domestic happiness" while Americans sought control over the intersex body to facilitate stability and certainty. The fetus is then an American icon - one with the possibility of a happy future that preserves national control and tradition, as well as a place of divergence where the intersex fetus and queer child destroy notions of a happy nuclear family.

Conservatives find stability when they are able to determine which bodies are acceptable and not: the nation is happy with greater control. Interestingly, Middleton pulls the quote "happiness is the biggest factor [in surgical intervention]. Anatomy is part of happiness" (Kessler, 2002:26), which could also be said by trans people. The overlap of autonomy and control when it comes to gender is inherently political; when we refuse to conform, we find our own happiness at the expense of national discomfort.

Refs:

Reis, Elizabeth. 2021. *Bodies in Doubt: An American History of Intersex*. 2nd ed. Baltimore: Johns Hopkins University Press

Morland, Iain. 2015. "Gender, Genitals, and the Meaning of Being Human." In *Fuckology: Critical Essays on John Money's Diagnostic Concepts*, by Downing, Lisa, Morland, Iain, and Sullivan, Nikki, 69–98. Chicago: University of Chicago Press.

Schweik, Susan M. 2009. *The Ugly Laws: Disability in Public*. New York: New York University Press.

Berlant, Lauren. 2002. "The Subject of True Feeling: Pain, Privacy, and Politics." In *Left Legalism/Left Critique*, edited by Brown, Wendy and Halley, Janet, 105–33. Durham, NC: Duke University Press.

Frivolous like Fashion - Simon(e) Van Saarloos

Simon(e) van Saarloos; Frivolous like Fashion. TSQ 1 May 2025; 12 (2): 259–262. doi: <https://doi.org/10.1215/23289252-11713393>

In this short personal essay, van Saarloos spins a fable that they "miraculously started walking after someone told me I looked cool". Van Saarloos fabulates a reality where their disability was willed into existence, that their dream became a reality and reality was just a dream. In this way, the attention they got from being disabled was because it was trendy, and transness too, is a trend. Van Saarloos seeks control of appearance by being disabled and trans. They feel shame over creating this "false" identity, but the idea of being loved just by naturally existing makes the superficial worth it. Trans is frivolous: trans sex workers seek surgery to be marketable, not because they experience internal womanhood. Real and "respectable" transness is internal and private, not based on the labor, sexuality, and the opinion of others. But the trend of being visibly trans, of having that identity, invites others to accept it

and be open to following the trend themselves. They hope that the same can work for disabled “identities”, that being visibly disabled can be desirable too.

I wasn’t sure where the sarcasm ended in this essay and struggled to distill van Saarloos’ true opinion on trans and disabled identity, but I believe the goal was to highlight the modern critique of transness being a trend in a pointful way. To imagine transness as something someone would go out of their way to be because it’s “cool” is radical in the face of ongoing oppression. They hope that that effort, in the context of transcrip theory, can afford disabled people more mobility and acceptance in the world.

Refs:

Amin, Kadji. 2023a. “The Respectability Politics of Gender Identity: A History.” Talk given at the Department of Gender, Sexuality, and Feminist Studies, Duke University, Durham, NC, October 4.

Amin, Kadji. 2023b. “Trans Materialism with Kadji Amin.” Interview by Mattheis, Lena. *Queer Lit* (podcast), April 17.

A Lingua Coca or “Secret Tongue?! My Ass!”: A Selection from “Neca” by Amara Moira - Amara Moira / Translated by Jesse Rothbard

Amara Moira, Jesse Rothbard; A Língua Coça or “Secret Tongue?! My Ass!”: A Selection from Neca by Amara Moira. *TSQ* 1 May 2025; 12 (2): 263–274. doi: <https://doi.org/10.1215/23289252-11713518>

This final submission to *TSQ* is an excerpt from Moira’s 2024 novel based on her experiences as a transgender (travesti) sex worker in Sao Paulo. The work is written in Bajuba, a Brazilian travesti language created to communicate in secret and a mix of Portuguese, West African languages, Spanish, French, and Italian. It is a monologue of an older travestis talking to a younger girl (the author) about her life and tips for sex work.

This work illuminates the variety of ways trans people experience their lives and mingle with normative society. And, like van Saarloos’ essay, come from a personal perspective rather than others (trans or not) talking about trans people as a whole or as a concept steeped in theory.

Refs:

Lucca, Bruno. 2023. “Brazil Is the Country That Most Kills Transsexuals and Travestites for the Fourteenth Year in a Row.” *Folha de São Paulo*, January 27. <https://www1.folha.uol.com.br/internacional/en/brazil/2023/01/brazil-is-the-country-that-most-kills-transsexuals-and-transvestites-for-the-14th-year-in-a-row.shtml>.

TSR2

Skirt Chasers: Why the Media Depicts the Trans Revolution in Lipstick and Hells by Julia Serano

Serano, Julia. "Skirt Chasers: Why the Media Depicts the Trans Revolution in Lipstick and Hells." *The Transgender Studies Reader 2*, edited by Susan Stryker and Aren Z. Aizura, New York, Routledge, 2013, pp. 226–233.

In this essay, Serano describes what she calls the "deceptive" and the "pathetic" types of trans women depicted in media. The "deceptive" trans women, often played by cis women in movies, are not known to be trans or "actually men" until a reveal later in the movie that involves feelings of disgust and violence that reduces her identity to an illusion that hides a perceived threat. The "pathetic" trans women, often played by cis men instead of cis women, do not resemble women; they fail to pass and, paired with bottom surgery, are not seen as harmful (rather, they are comedic). Serano also notes that trans women are more sensational than trans men, because the idea of someone wanting to be more masculine is taken for granted/normal. The idea of giving up male privilege to be a woman is insane and sexualized: it is assumed trans women transition to be overly feminine and attract male attention.

Serano's main point is that feminism suffers from transmisogyny. The media focuses on portrayals of overtly feminine trans women, showcasing the acts of putting on lipstick, dresses, and heels, even when the focus of the media is not about transition, to emphasize the "performance" of femininity. This portrayal "encourages the objectification of women as a whole" and leads to trans men being ignored because to sensationalize the desire to be masculine would question masculinity itself. Serano also notes, based on Janice G. Raymond's book *The Transsexual Empire: The Making of the She-Male* and from her own experience, that trans women are put into a double-bind: act feminine and be considered a parody, or act masculine and reveal yourself as a male.

Refs:

Raymond, Janice G, and Beacon Press Boston. *The Transsexual Empire: The Making of the She-Male*. Boston, Beacon Press, Copyright, 1979.

Califa, Patrick. Sex Changes: *The Politics of Transgenderism*. 1997.

The Education of the Little Cis: Cisgender and the Discipline of Opposing Bodies by A. Finn Enke

Enke, A. Finn. "The Education of the Little Cis: Cisgender and the Discipline of Opposing Bodies." *The Transgender Studies Reader 2*, edited by Susan Stryker and Aren Z. Aizura, New York, Routledge, 2013, pp. 234–247.

Enke begins by informing the reader that the first use of cisgender is credited to biologist Dana Leland Defosse in 1994, who suggested cis- as a compliment to trans- based on the Latin root and its use in biological terminology. The idea early on was that cisgender described those

who stayed consistent with their assigned gender at birth, but “nowadays, cisgender commonly implies staying *within* certain gender parameters...rather than *crossing*...those parameters”. Enke suggests that cisgender is really only used by trans communities, but, based partly on his/her observations in his/her classroom, is gaining traction on college campuses. The movement of the terms “cis” and “cisgender” provides insight into the effect of language on gender politics. While there were debates in Enke’s classroom about the word itself, those debates educated others who had not been aware of the term(s) before. Some of the cisgender students, realizing the term’s conflation with normativity and the separation from those who are transgender, were insulted by being othered. With the emergence of the term transgender to describe those who crossed normative gender signifiers or identities came a normalization within trans and trans activist circles to be visibly different (via name, body, pronouns, etc.). This shift then required those visible differences, along with aspects of nonvisibility, to belong to a chosen gender group with transparency and authenticity. Transgender identities are then informed by what individuals do, and cisgender became necessary to define and use.

Both transgender and cisgender remain broad categories and seemingly satisfy in their ability to name systemic oppression experienced by one and not the other. However, cisgender students, Enke observed, inadvertently do not relate to transgender experiences, even if it is an overlapping experience such as misogyny, and also seek to further differentiate themselves as the “cis ally”. Enke argues that students verbally acknowledging themselves as cis reinforces their privilege by further differentiating cis and trans. Defosse wrote in 2006, after witnessing some misinterpretation of her initial use of cis, “cis and trans are not just where something is, however; they extend to the realms of their respective effects”. While the use of cis may have twisted to imply stasis, Defosse was originally attempting to differentiate trans and cis experiences, not invalidating the effects of time and space on cis people, as has been well established in academia with trans persons. Enke furthers his/her argument by discussing his/her varied trans identity across his/her lifetime, and how the demand of cis people and other trans people to be transparently trans highlights cis privilege.

Our Bodies Are Not Ourselves: Tranny Guys and the Racialized Class Politics of Incoherence by Bobby Jean Noble

Noble, Bobby J. “Our Bodies Are Not Ourselves: Tranny Guys and the Racialized Class Politics of Incoherence.” *The Transgender Studies Reader 2*, edited by Susan Stryker and Aren Z. Aizura, New York, Routledge, 2013, pp. 248–258.

Noble describes himself as “formerly off-white and now White” in the context of his transition from a white, working-class, butch woman to a white, transgender man able to benefit from white male supremacy. Considering anti-racism and classism, he professes that “whiteness comes into visibility as whiteness when it is articulated through class” and then questions how trans men are viewed from a feminist lens when intersecting with class, capitalism, and race. Noble feels deeply connected to his ancestry and personal history of working-class women and men and how those years cannot be forgotten when considering the influences on his current gender: mentally and physically “a guy who is half lesbian”.

Noble asks white trans men not to become “The Man”, to be cognizant of their white masculinity and the privilege that affords. He recounts how now when he enters queer spaces, or what he calls “No Man’s Land”, he is now suspect to lesbians, cruised by gay men, and feels the need to be physically closer to his girlfriend of African descent, who will be read as Black or as queer but often not both. In this way, Noble purposely outs himself as a kind of race traitor in effort to stay true to his anti-racist critical practice, which is a unique effort for white trans men who have lived as butch lesbians. In the same vein, Noble demands that feminism acknowledge its complicity in biological essentialism.

Refs:

Cameron, Loren. *Body Alchemy : Transsexual Portraits*. San Francisco, Cleis Press, 1996.

The Pharmo-Pornographic Regime: Sex, Gender, and Subjectivity in the Age of Punk Capitalism by Beatrix Preciado

Preciado, Beatrix. “The Pharmo-Pornographic Regime: Sex, Gender, and Subjectivity in the Age of Punk Capitalism.” *The Transgender Studies Reader 2*, edited by Susan Stryker and Aren Z. Aizura, New York, Routledge, 2013, pp. 266–277.

Preciado coins the term farmacopornografico to describe the influence of drugs, plastic, and gender-affirming surgery, biotechnology, mass media, and hypersexuality on our lives in a post-WWII world. Humans’ mental and bodily functions have been injected with prescribed drugs, surgeries, sex, and technology that can be encapsulated by the modern transgender experience. Preciado notes that, during the Cold War, the US spent more money than any country previously on scientific research related to sex and sexuality while capitalism had shifted to converting the same topics, along with sexual identity and pleasure, into profitable objects used for political management. At the same time, women’s and homosexuals’ visibility in public spaces grew and hormones and surgeries became more available to transgender persons.

Preciado references Foucault’s observation, at the end of the 1900s, of the transition of a sovereign society to a disciplinary society: previously, power decided and ritualized death; now, power is built through technologies of subjugation via population, health, and national interest. Preciado recognizes a second shift, from a disciplinary to a bio-capitalist pharmaco-pornographic society, which controls the populace through technologies that enter the body and form part of it. Legal and illegal drugs have become fuel and a form of control for a technologically modernizing populace. Definitions and studies on gender, masculinity, and femininity are part and parcel to this new power. Preciado states that gender (femininity/masculinity) is not a concept, ideology, or performance, but rather a techno-political ecology; self-determination is overtaken by the subjectivity of identity. This is the case for binary identities, but further gender variants, the act of “undoing gender” (coined by Judith Butler), and self-experimentation (along with refusal of prescriptions) become micro-political movements that usurp normative descriptions and demands of identity.

Refs (names instead of books): Kate Bornstein, Pat Califia, Del LaGrace Volcano, Dean Spade, Jacob Hale, Sandy Stone, Moises Martinez, John Money, Robert Stoller, and Foucault.

Extermination of the Joyas: Gendercide in Spanish California by Deborah A. Miranda

Miranda, Deborah A. "Extermination of the Joyas: Gendercide in Spanish California." *The Transgender Studies Reader 2*, edited by Susan Stryker and Aren Z. Aizura, New York, Routledge, 2013, pp. 350–363.

Reading Transsexuality in "Gay" Tehran (Around 1979) by Afsaneh Najmabadi

Najmabadi, Afsaneh. "Reading Transsexuality in "Gay" Tehran (Around 1979)." *The Transgender Studies Reader 2*, edited by Susan Stryker and Aren Z. Aizura, New York, Routledge, 2013, pp. 380–399.

In this chapter, Najmabadi recounts a history of the "gay paradise" that was Tehran in the 1970s prior to the 1979 Islamic Revolution that brought stricter rules on gender presentation and execution of those accused of homosexuality. Prior to the revolution, gay and trans distinctions were blurred, spaces that centered male dancers who dressed femininely were safe locations for non-heteronormative men to find others like themselves. Many (who may self-identify as nonbinary or transfeminine today) congregated in these spaces for fun and community, while romantic relationships happened elsewhere, even to the extent of living double lives: men by day, women by night. Being openly a "male dressing as a woman" or a female "living [an] unusual masculine [life]" was scandalous and fascinating to the public, something to be written about or paraded on stage. Theater, cinema, and dance clubs were often the only available vocations for "men dressing up as women".

While Western gay men saw this as utopic (informed by orientalism), some Iranians saw the greater visibility of non-heteronormative men and spaces as corruption from Westernization (hence the following revolution). Tehran was by no means a safe space for gay or trans people, but (as was the case in the West as well) there were safe pockets where queer people (mainly non-heteronormative "men") could thrive. "Sex-change" surgeries became more popular for trans women and "female presenting men", even being talked about in media sympathetically. However, the Medical Council of Iran became alarmed with the increase of these non-normative surgeries (originally used for intersex persons) and enforced a connection between homosexuality, mental instability, and transfemmes which led to a ban of these surgeries (beyond intersex sex-change purposes) in 1976. Hormone therapy was available, but transfemmes began to go abroad for surgeries. However, many "woman-presenting men" were forced to conform to masculine standards of dress for work, especially soon after the revolution, when imprisonment and execution on charges of "prostitution and sodomy" came into practice.

Shuttling Between Bodies and Borders: Iranian Transsexual Refugees and the Politics of Rightful Killing by Sima Shakhsar

Shakhsar, Sima. "Shuttling Between Bodies and Borders: Iranian Transsexual Refugees and the Politics of Rightful Killing." *The Transgender Studies Reader 2*, edited by Susan Stryker and Aren Z. Aizura, New York, Routledge, 2013, pp. 565–379.